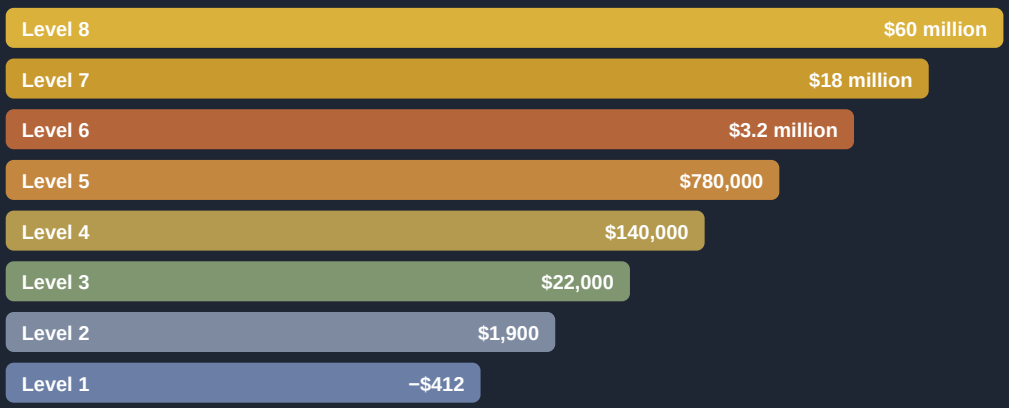
NARRATION SCRIPT · LADDER FORMAT · 8 LEVELS

POV: What Your Family Stops Telling You at Every Level of Wealth



−$412 → $60,000,000

— Nobody tells you the one thing that matters



2,415	17:17	20	140
WORDS	RUNTIME	CHAPTERS	WORDS / MIN

Interactive: tap a chapter to jump to it, tick boxes as you finish each stage, type notes in the boxes. The bookmarks panel lists every chapter. Timecodes match voiceover.mp3 (Kokoro “Michael”). Best in Adobe Acrobat Reader, Xodo, Foxit or a desktop browser so ticks and notes save.

NARRATION SCRIPT

What Your Family Stops Telling You

Tap a chapter to jump to it.

2,415 words · 17:17 · 20 chapters · 257 images

Record each chapter or send it to your voice tool, then tick Recorded, Images and Edited as you go. Image numbers match image-prompts.pdf. Timecodes are from voiceover.mp3.

#	CHAPTER	TIME	IMAGES	DONE
1	**The $3.79 soap** Level 1 · −$412 · “It always says approved.”	00:00–01:18	#001–017	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
2	**Sunday at Nana's** Level 1 · −$412 · Everyone tells you everything	01:18–02:13	#018–031	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
3	**The blue tin** Level 1 · −$412 · Two folded twenties, soft as cloth	02:13–02:47	#032–041	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
4	**The night shift** Level 2 · $1,900 · Eleven months later, the minus sign is gone	02:47–03:43	#042–055	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
5	**Keep yours** Level 2 · $1,900 · “We’re fine. Keep yours.”	03:43–04:48	#056–071	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
6	**The kitchen table** Level 3 · $22,000 · Fourteen agencies, $90 a month	04:48–05:43	#072–087	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
7	**Prices** Level 3 · $22,000 · Prices are for people who might pay	05:43–06:47	#088–102	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
8	**The quiet car** Level 4 · $140,000 · A real mug. Not paper.	06:47–07:33	#103–114	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
9	**The transmission** Level 4 · $140,000 · He doesn’t know what he’s allowed to say no to	07:33–08:37	#115–131	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
10	**The deposit** Level 5 · $780,000 · Your latte costs $6.25	08:37–09:30	#132–144	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
11	**The story he stopped telling** Level 5 · $780,000 · You only tease equals	09:30–10:32	#145–160	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
12	**The cake** Level 6 · $3.2 million · Who sends a cake?	10:32–11:16	#161–170	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
13	**The other chat** Level 6 · $3.2 million · Same people. Minus you.	11:16–11:48	#171–177	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
14	**The barbecue binder** Level 6 · $3.2 million · He thanks you in a voice you don’t recognize	11:48–12:25	#178–186	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
15	**Nine minutes** Level 7 · $18 million · Nine minutes. Nine.	12:25–13:23	#187–201	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
16	**Nothing to buy** Level 7 · $18 million · “You’d have tried to fix it.”	13:23–14:21	#202–216	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
17	**The room with no clocks** Level 8 · $60 million · You vote with the room	14:21–15:18	#217–228	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
18	**The steel wall** Level 8 · $60 million · He can tell by how people are acting	15:18–15:55	#229–238	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
19	**Nobody needed it** Level 8 · $60 million · “Nobody needed it.”	15:55–16:29	#239–246	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit
20	**Somewhere right now** Outro · Everyone’s fine. They keep saying so.	16:29–17:17	#247–257	☐ Rec ☐ Img ☐ Edit

CHAPTER 1 OF 20 · LEVEL 1 · −$412

The $3.79 soap

“It always says approved.”

00:00 – 01:18
177 words · images #001–#017

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

00:00 Level one, negative $412. It starts with a bottle of laundry detergent. $3.79. You buy it at 11:40 on a Tuesday night at the corner store next to the laundromat, because the machines eat quarters and you forgot soap.

00:18 You tap your card without thinking. The card reader beeps. Approved. That's the cruel part. It always says approved.

00:28 The next morning there's a text from your bank. Overdraft fee. $35. For $3.79 of soap. By Friday, two more charges clear behind it, a $9 phone app and a $14 tank of gas, and each one gets its own $35.

00:47 Your balance reads negative $412. You didn't spend $412. You were charged for being short.

00:56 You call the bank on your lunch break. Forty-one minutes of hold music. The same eight bars of piano, over and over.

01:04 Then a woman who reads you a policy in a voice like a parking meter. She can't reverse it.

01:10 She can offer a courtesy review in five to seven business days. You thank her. You don't know why you thank her.

← Chapter overview Next: Sunday at Nana's →

CHAPTER 2 OF 20 · LEVEL 1 · −$412

Sunday at Nana's

Everyone tells you everything

01:18 – 02:13
140 words · images #018–#031

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

01:18 Sunday, you drive to Nana's. The screen door bangs twice behind you, the way it has since you were six.

01:26 Everybody's there. Uncle Pete. Your sister Renée. Your parents. Two cousins and a casserole.

01:34 And here's the thing about this level. Everyone tells you everything. Pete tells you to get a second job.

01:40 Renée tells you about her raise, $4,000, then the apartment she's eyeing, then the guy she's seeing. Your mother tells you banks are a racket.

01:50 Your father tells you, "You need a plan," three times between the salad and the ham.

01:56 Nobody tells you the one thing that matters. Your father's hours got cut in March. Thirty-two a week now, down from forty.

02:05 You find out in August, from an envelope on the counter. When you ask him, he folds it in half and says, "We're fine."

← Chapter overview Next: The blue tin →

CHAPTER 3 OF 20 · LEVEL 1 · −$412

The blue tin

Two folded twenties, soft as cloth

02:13 – 02:47
80 words · images #032–#041

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

02:13 Before you leave, Nana walks you to the car. She presses something into your jacket pocket. You don't look until you're on the highway.

02:22 Two twenties, folded into quarters, soft as cloth. From the blue cookie tin on top of her fridge.

02:29 The one that has never once held cookies.

02:32 Not charity. Just Nana.

02:35 The first rule. At negative $412, your family tells you everything except what they're carrying. They don't hide it from you. They hide it for you.

← Chapter overview Next: The night shift →

CHAPTER 4 OF 20 · LEVEL 2 · $1,900

The night shift

Eleven months later, the minus sign is gone

02:47 – 03:43
133 words · images #042–#055

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

02:47 Level two, $1,900. Eleven months later, the minus sign is gone. You work nights at a parcel sorting center now, six in the evening to two-thirty in the morning, the conveyor humming so loud you hear it in your sleep.

03:03 In the mornings you teach yourself to code on a laptop with a cracked hinge. $1,900 in checking.

03:11 You look at it the way you'd look at a candle in wind.

03:14 The bank notices before your family does. A new email. "You may be eligible for overdraft protection." Now. Now they offer it.

03:25 At the pharmacy counter, picking up your mother's blood pressure pills, the tech rings up $62 and your card goes through on the first try.

03:34 You almost laugh. She doesn't look up. Nobody notices $1,900. That's the gift of it.

← Chapter overview Next: Keep yours →

CHAPTER 5 OF 20 · LEVEL 2 · $1,900

Keep yours

“We’re fine. Keep yours.”

03:43 – 04:48
156 words · images #056–#071

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

03:43 At Nana's, Pete still gives you advice. But it's shorter. Renée still tells you about her week. But now she asks about yours, and waits for the answer.

03:54 Your father says, "You're doing better." Not a question. A test.

03:59 You offer to cover the electric bill. $180. He looks at you like you said something rude. "We're fine," he says. Then, quieter, "Keep yours."

04:11 Here's what nobody tells you. The first time you have a little extra, the people who raised you get very careful about not needing it.

04:20 Not pride. Protection. They're guarding the version of you that just got up off the floor.

04:27 Nana walks you to the car again. Her hand drifts toward your pocket. You catch it. You shake your head.

04:34 She looks at you for a long second, then pats your cheek instead.

04:39 The second rule. At $1,900, they stop telling you what they need. Because you might actually give it.

← Chapter overview Next: The kitchen table →

CHAPTER 6 OF 20 · LEVEL 3 · $22,000

The kitchen table

Fourteen agencies, $90 a month

04:48 – 05:43
143 words · images #072–#087

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

04:48 Level three, $22,000. The code turns into something. A scheduling tool for home care aides, the people who drive between six houses a day and keep their shifts on paper.

05:01 You built it at a kitchen table. Fourteen agencies pay you $90 a month. You quit the sorting center on a Thursday.

05:10 The quiet in your ears that night is so loud you can't sleep.

05:14 $22,000. You sit down with a loan officer at a credit union about a small business line. He has a dish of mints and a framed photo of a fishing trip.

05:25 He reads your balance and his whole posture changes, like someone adjusted his chair. He uses your first name.

05:34 He says, "We like to see this." Two years ago, it was forty-one minutes of piano. Today, he writes his cell number on the back of a card.

← Chapter overview Next: Prices →

CHAPTER 7 OF 20 · LEVEL 3 · $22,000

Prices

Prices are for people who might pay

05:43 – 06:47
143 words · images #088–#102

DIRECTOR NOTES

Recorded Images Edited

05:43 At Nana's, something small shifts. When Renée shows off new boots, Pete asks her what she paid. $140.

05:52 She tells him. When you show up in a new coat, nobody asks. Not once.

05:58 You notice that. You notice everything now.

06:02 Later, Renée corners you by the coffee maker. She's moving in with the guy. She says the deposit is "a lot."

06:10 She doesn't say how much. You ask. She says, "Don't worry about it." Then she tells you anyway.

06:18 $2,400. You send it from the bathroom before dessert.

06:22 She texts you a heart. Just a heart. In the family group chat, the one called The Porch, she posts a photo of new keys, and everyone says congratulations.

06:33 Nobody knows. You don't tell them. Neither does she.

06:38 The third rule. At $22,000, they stop telling you prices. Prices are for people who might pay.

← Chapter overview Next: The quiet car →

CHAPTER 8 OF 20 · LEVEL 4 · $140,000

The quiet car

A real mug. Not paper.

06:47 – 07:33
103 words · images #103–#114

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

06:47 Level four, $140,000. Two hundred agencies. Nine employees. An office above a dry cleaner that smells like steam and starch. $140,000 in the business account and a salary you set yourself, which is a strange thing to type.

07:08 At the car dealership, the salesman sees the trade-in, then the pre-approval, then you. He brings coffee in a real mug.

07:16 Not paper. He stops saying "this one's popular" and starts saying "this one's quiet."

07:22 The bank stops emailing. A person calls instead. Her name is Dana. She has a direct line and a calm voice, and she has never once put you on hold.

← Chapter overview Next: The transmission →

CHAPTER 9 OF 20 · LEVEL 4 · $140,000

The transmission

He doesn’t know what he’s allowed to say no to

07:33 – 08:37
154 words · images #115–#131

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

07:33 Then your father's truck needs a transmission. $3,800. You hear about it from Pete, in the driveway, by accident.

07:42 You walk inside and offer. Your father says, "We're fine." This time you don't argue. You just call the shop on Monday and pay it.

07:51 He doesn't bring it up. Not that week. Not the next. At Sunday dinner he's polite with you.

07:59 Careful. Like you're a guest who might break something.

08:02 Your mother says, "He's not mad." She pauses. "He just doesn't know what he's allowed to say no to anymore."

08:10 But here's the part that changes you. The day you can fix anything, people stop arguing with you.

08:17 Pete used to tell you your ideas were dumb. Loudly. With his mouth full. He hasn't said it in a year.

08:24 You didn't notice the silence until it was total.

08:28 The fourth rule. At $140,000, they stop telling you no. They just stop calling instead.

← Chapter overview Next: The deposit →

CHAPTER 10 OF 20 · LEVEL 5 · $780,000

The deposit

Your latte costs $6.25

08:37 – 09:30
115 words · images #132–#144

DIRECTOR NOTES

Recorded Images Edited

08:37 Level five, $780,000. An investor flies in. A small firm. They buy twenty percent of the company. Your share after taxes is $780,000, and it lands at 2:14 on a Wednesday afternoon.

08:56 You're in a coffee shop. Your latte costs $6.25. You stare at the receipt longer than the deposit.

09:03 At this number, Dana has a manager, and the manager wants lunch. He orders for the table. He asks how old your parents are. He's very interested in planning.

09:15 You buy a house twenty minutes from Nana's. Four bedrooms. Sunday dinners start drifting your way. Nobody decides it.

09:23 Nana's knees get worse, your kitchen is bigger, and one week The Porch just says, "At yours?"

← Chapter overview Next: The story he stopped telling →

CHAPTER 11 OF 20 · LEVEL 5 · $780,000

The story he stopped telling

You only tease equals

09:30 – 10:32
148 words · images #145–#160

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

09:30 At your table, Pete doesn't tell the story about you locking your keys in the car with the engine running.

09:37 He used to tell it every year. Everybody laughed. You laughed loudest. This year he starts it, glances at you, and stops halfway.

09:46 He turns it into a story about the weather.

09:49 Jokes are the first thing to leave. You only tease equals.

09:54 Renée brings her boyfriend. He shakes your hand like he's meeting a landlord. Your nephew, four years old, asks why your house has so many doors. Everyone laughs too hard.

10:06 After dinner, you find Nana's blue tin on your counter. She brought it from her house. You open it.

10:14 Rubber bands. A spool of thread. Three twenties. You add ten more. You don't tell her.

10:21 The fifth rule. At $780,000, they stop telling the stories where you look small. And those were your favorite ones.

← Chapter overview Next: The cake →

CHAPTER 12 OF 20 · LEVEL 6 · $3.2 MILLION

The cake

Who sends a cake?

10:32 – 11:16
99 words · images #161–#170

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

10:32 Level six, $3.2 million.

10:36 The company sells a second stake. Bigger firm. Glass building. A pen that weighs more than your first phone.

10:44 Your share is $3.2 million. You sign, ride the elevator down forty floors, and sit in the parking garage for twenty-two minutes with the radio off.

10:55 Now the bank finds you. Dana is gone. There's a team. A relationship manager named Corinne, a tax person, an estate person, a person whose job you never fully understand.

11:08 They call before you think to call them. They know your birthday. They send a cake. Who sends a cake?

← Chapter overview

Next: The other chat →

CHAPTER 13 OF 20 · LEVEL 6 · $3.2 MILLION

The other chat

Same people. Minus you.

11:16 – 11:48
71 words · images #171–#177

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

11:16 The Porch gets quieter. Fewer pings. Then you learn why. Renée mentions "the other chat" by accident. There's a second one.

11:26 Same people. Minus you. Not cruel. Practical. Somewhere to talk about money without the person who has it.

11:34 You ask your mother. She says, "Oh, that's nothing." Then, "We didn't want everything to feel like it was about you."

11:42 Not exclusion. Courtesy. That's what makes it impossible to argue with.

← Chapter overview Next: The barbecue binder →

CHAPTER 14 OF 20 · LEVEL 6 · $3.2 MILLION

The barbecue binder

He thanks you in a voice you don’t recognize

11:48 – 12:25
91 words · images #178–#186

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

11:48 Pete pitches you a barbecue restaurant. He's been working on the menu for six years. He wants $75,000.

11:57 You read it. It isn't good. And for the first time, the man who once called your ideas dumb sits across from you, waiting for you to call his dumb, and you can't.

12:07 You write a check for $40,000 and a note that says good luck. He thanks you in a voice you don't recognize.

12:16 The sixth rule. At $3.2 million, they stop telling you the truth. And you stop telling it back.

← Chapter overview Next: Nine minutes →

CHAPTER 15 OF 20 · LEVEL 7 · $18 MILLION

Nine minutes

Nine minutes. Nine.

12:25 – 13:23
123 words · images #187–#201

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

12:25 Level seven, $18 million. The full sale. Everything. The software, the team, the office that smelled like steam. A larger company buys it in a deal that takes nine months and a hundred and forty pages. Your number is $18 million.

12:44 Your father has been tired. Your mother mentions it once, in October, and never again. In December, he forgets your nephew's name at dinner.

12:54 Just for a second. He laughs it off.

12:57 You call a concierge medical practice. $12,000 a year to join. The receptionist calls back in nine minutes.

13:06 Nine. You remember forty-one minutes of piano over a $35 fee. A neurologist sees your father that Thursday.

13:15 Every scan money can buy. Every second opinion. Results in four days.

13:21 Early-stage dementia.

← Chapter overview

Next: Nothing to buy →

CHAPTER 16 OF 20 · LEVEL 7 · $18 MILLION

Nothing to buy

“You’d have tried to fix it.”

13:23 – 14:21
138 words · images #202–#216

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

13:23 The doctor is kind. She speaks slowly. She keeps a box of tissues on the desk at exactly the right angle.

13:31 And there's nothing to buy. You look. You actually look. A trial. A clinic. A specialist overseas. There is no level where this one goes away.

13:44 You find out later. He'd known something was wrong for a year. He told your mother. He told Pete. He told Nana. He didn't tell you.

13:54 When you finally ask why, he sits on your porch in the good chair you bought him and says, "You'd have tried to fix it."

14:02 Not secrecy. Mercy. He wanted one problem you couldn't own.

14:07 Then he looks out at the yard and says, "We're fine."

14:11 The seventh rule. At $18 million, they stop telling you when they're scared. Because your fear costs too much.

← Chapter overview

Next: The room with no clocks →

CHAPTER 17 OF 20 · LEVEL 8 · $60 MILLION

The room with no clocks

You vote with the room

14:21 – 15:18
111 words · images #217–#228

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

14:21 Level eight, $60 million. The money grows without you now. You don't work. It works. Funds. Buildings. Stakes in things you've never seen.

14:33 People ask you to sit on boards. You say yes to one. A regional bank. Quarterly meetings in a room with no clocks.

14:42 At your third meeting, a slide goes up. Fee revenue. One line reads, "Overdraft, $35 per occurrence." Projected annual income, $212 million.

14:56 Someone asks if the number is defensible. Someone else says customers value the convenience. Everyone nods. A woman refills your sparkling water before you ask.

15:08 You think about $3.79 of detergent. A Tuesday. 11:40 at night.

15:15 You vote. You vote with the room.

← Chapter overview

Next: The steel wall →

CHAPTER 18 OF 20 · LEVEL 8 · $60 MILLION

The steel wall

He can tell by how people are acting

15:18 – 15:55
101 words · images #229–#238

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

15:18 You fund a memory care wing at the county hospital. They put your family name on the wall in brushed steel.

15:25 Your father stands in front of it in a shirt your mother ironed, and doesn't quite know why he's there.

15:31 He knows it's important. He can tell by how people are acting.

15:35 At Sunday dinner, everyone is pleasant. Everyone is fine. Renée tells you nothing about her marriage, which is coming apart, which you learn from your nephew.

15:46 Pete's restaurant closed in March. He never mentioned it. In The Porch, you get birthday wishes and baby photos and nothing else.

← Chapter overview Next: Nobody needed it →

CHAPTER 19 OF 20 · LEVEL 8 · $60 MILLION

Nobody needed it

“Nobody needed it.”

15:55 – 16:29
79 words · images #239–#246

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

15:55 After everyone leaves, you find the blue tin on your counter. Nana's been gone two winters. Somebody keeps bringing it to your house anyway.

16:04 You open it. Your twenties. All of them. Untouched. And a strip of paper in your mother's handwriting. "Nobody needed it."

16:15 You stand in your kitchen and hold the tin for a long time.

16:19 The eighth rule. At $60 million, your family stops telling you anything you could change. Which turns out to be everything.

← Chapter overview Next: Somewhere right now →

CHAPTER 20 OF 20 · OUTRO

Somewhere right now

Everyone’s fine. They keep saying so.

16:29 – 17:17
110 words · images #247–#257

DIRECTOR NOTES

☐ Recorded ☐ Images ☐ Edited

16:29 Somewhere right now, someone is standing in a corner store at 11:40 on a Tuesday night, holding a $3.79 bottle of detergent.

16:39 The card reader beeps. Approved. Tomorrow there'll be a $35 fee, and forty-one minutes of piano, and a voice like a parking meter.

16:49 On Sunday, a screen door will bang twice behind them. Everyone at that table will tell them exactly what they're doing wrong.

16:58 And on the way out, a grandmother will slip two folded twenties into their jacket pocket.

17:04 They think the worst part is how much everyone tells them.

17:08 It isn't. The worst part is the day it stops.

17:13 Everyone's fine. They keep saying so.

← Chapter overview Back to cover ↑